CLEAR PATH LEADERSHIP

Book Bites:
A Monthly Leadership Series

METRO TECH

A best-selling book by Jefferson Fisher

THE NEXT CONVERSATION: ARGUE LESS, TALK MORE



What if the goal of an argument wasn't to win, but to connect?

Communication is a crucial skill, both at work and in our personal lives. However, our most crucial conversations often turn into arguments because we're more concerned with proving ourselves right than understanding (or connecting with) the other person. Jefferson Fisher argues that we can communicate clearly and effectively, even when emotions are high, by prioritizing speaking with control, confidence, and the ultimate goal of connection.

Key Ideas:

01 You should never win an argument

In arguments, the person you see often isn't the person you're really talking to. It's better to think about an argument as an opportunity to understand the person we're talking to. When we make connection - not proving ourselves right - our ultimate goal, we're about to resolve tension, find common ground, and come out on the other side with a stronger relationship.

02 Say it with control

Most arguments begin with an "ignition" phase, where self-preservation is the goal of both sides. To alleviate this tension, we should pay attention to what triggers us, control our breath as we speak, and use silence as a tool to convey composure and wisdom. This is crucial as a conversation begins, because once the metaphorical storm hits, controlling it only becomes harder.

03 Say it with confidence

Confidence is a feeling, but asking how to feel confident is the wrong question. It must be an active process, because real confidence is found in the "doing." In conversations, we can convey confidence by avoiding filler words, advocating for ourselves, speaking up when it matters, making eye contact throughout (but especially at tne end), and using silence when appropriate.

04 Say it to connect

One way to strengthen the connection between two parties in communication is by creating "frames" to eliminate uncertainty and ambiguity in a conversation. We can also respond with grace and curiosity when someone appears defensive, and we can embrace difficult conversations as some of the best opportunities for connection.

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THE NEXT CONVERSATION BY JEFFERSON FISHER

Reflection Question(s)

1. The next time you find yourself in an argument, how can you prioritize connection over "winning?"
2. What's one way you can speak with more control?
3. What's one way you can speak with more confidence?
4. If connection was a primary goal of your conversations (even the difficult ones), how would your relationships be different?
5. How do you want people to feel when they are communicating with you? What's one idea from "The Next Conversation" that might help you?

Challenge

Choose one focus to prioritize in your conversations over the next few weeks (control, confidence, or connection). Keep a journal where you reflect on how things are going, what's working well, how you are improving, and what growth you would still like to see.

> It doesn't matter how insignificant you think you are, your words have power beyond anything you'll live to see. The right sentence to the right person can change lives.
>
> Jefferson Fisher, *The Next Conversation*